Los Angeles Times

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Feds deploy election watchers to L.A.

The late surge adds to turmoil over voting as Justice Department presses its case.

By Sonja Sharp

The Justice Department sent a last-minute surge of election monitors into Los Angeles on Tuesday morning, amid an ongoing legal tug-of-war over California's 20,000 contested ballots.

In a series of rulings late Monday night and early Tuesday, the U.S. 9th Circuit Court of Appeals cleared the Trump administration to threaten California election workers with criminal charges, even after its demands to segregate contested ballots were struck down by the Supreme Court.

The appellate court's final decision came on election day, just after the Justice Department announced it was sending out "1,000 election monitors and observers" across the U.S. in what it called "the largest monitoring effort in DOJ history."

Los Angeles, New York, Chicago and Detroit were among the dozens of jurisdictions where monitors were sent under the auspices of the Voting Rights Act of 1965 — legislation that President Trump has worked tirelessly to gut across both his administrations.

The Justice Department said it also would send monitors to San Diego, Sacramento and Alameda County in the San Francisco Bay Area. A department spokesperson said that the federal monitors "will be at polling locations," but that the department is not "giving out precinct details."

The move was widely seen as an intimidation tactic.

[See Monitors, A6]





Photographs by Genaro Molina Los Angeles Times

WORTH THE WAIT

People cast their ballots at Grand Central Market, top, in downtown Los Angeles on Tuesday. At USC, voters waited more than an hour. Scan this code to read our coverage at latimes.com and in our eNewspaper, where subscribers get an exclusive "LATExtra."

Little room for error for the next mayor of L.A.

Whoever is elected faces slew of problems, including on budget, police and housing.

By Jenny Jarvie

Homeless encampments line the streets. Buying a home — or even finding an affordable place to rent — is increasingly out of reach for many. Roads are riddled with potholes, tens of thousands of streetlights are out, and water and power bills are surging.

For many Angelenos, quality of life in the city is slipping.

These challenges have left some longtime political experts wondering how much the next mayor can control in this vast city of 3.8 million.

"The expectations, given the powers that the mayor actually has, are probably too high," said Tom Hogen-Esch, a professor of political science at Cal State Northridge. "You have all of these wicked problems that are difficult to solve in a perfect scenario, and [even more] in a governmental system as tangled and confused as L.A."

Along with the enduring problems of deteriorating infrastructure, police reform and budget woes, there is also the unprecedented task of rebuilding Pacific Palisades after catastrophic firestorms and trying to help the city's ailing film industry — all while preparing the city for the global spotlight of hosting the 2028 Olympics.

A recent UC Berkeley Institute of Governmental Studies poll of likely L.A. voters, co-sponsored by The Times, found that the top priority for the next mayor to address was reducing the number of homeless encampments, followed by ensuring public safety and building more affordable housing. Protecting immigrant communities was the next most cited concern, followed by balancing the city budget.

After studying L.A. politics for more than three decades, Hogen-Esch said the city feels stuck.

"We're talking about the same issues over and over and over ... and a general underlying frustration with city government," he said. "It's almost like you could wake up 30 years later in a Rip Van Winkle dream and you're in the same spot."

Homelessness

When Karen Bass launched her 2021 mayoral campaign, she proclaimed homelessness was her "overwhelming top priority."

After nearly four years of her leadership, she has failed to make a serious dent on homelessness. This year, the Los Angeles Homeless Services Authority announced that more than 45,194 people in the city were homeless — not significantly different from 46,260 homeless people in January 2023.

After spending more than $391 million on Inside Safe, Bass' flagship program to clean up homeless encampments and house homeless people, the city moved about 6,500 people into interim housing. But about 42% of the program's participants have returned to homelessness.

Bass says Inside Safe has made progress, clearing 140 encampments across the city. But the difference is not visible to many residents as encampments continue to

[See Mayor, A6]

Real work awaits Democrats in state

Party maintains its grip on California but will have to deal with its chronic problems.

By Jenny Jarvie

For all their dominance, California Democrats will emerge from Tuesday's election facing a list of considerable difficulties.

As polls show nearly 6 out of 10 Californians believe the state is going in the wrong direction and even more anticipate bad financial times ahead, the state's new governor and legislators will have to confront some chronic problems, including a severe budget deficit, housing unaffordability, homelessness, and rising energy and insurance costs.

They will also have to grapple with difficult decisions on whether the state can provide Medi-Cal healthcare to low-income residents, how to make the state more resilient to climate change, and who pays for wildfire damage.

"There's not going to be a long honeymoon period," said Mark Baldassare, the survey director at the nonpartisan Public Policy Institute of California.

Californians are in a "pretty grumpy mood," Baldassare said. Although their dissatisfaction is mostly hyperpartisan, with Democrats pointing the finger at President Trump and Congress as Republicans blame Gov. Gavin Newsom and Sacramento legislators, he said, a majority of Californians are worried about the state of the economy and want to see better government performance.

For voters, a key concern is unaffordability. More than half of Californians rank cost of living, inflation and the economy — along with hous-

[See Democrats, A7]

Specter of new fighting grips Mideast

Mixed U.S. signals on Iran war stoke fears of more dangerous, more destructive escalation.

By Nabih Bulos

MANAMA, Bahrain — Conferences in the Persian Gulf are usually positive affairs, with government officials, executives of state-owned companies and armies of consultants touting petro-fueled visions promising fantastical technology and prosperity.

Yet optimism seemed in short supply at the Manama Dialogue, an annual security and geopolitical summit held in the Bahraini capital. Instead, the dominant mood among the Middle East diplomats, defense officials and experts assembled last weekend was fear over the consequences of another bout of U.S.-Iran fighting.

"The rules of logic tell us that the Iranian stand and the American stand are far apart. And if these positions are not bridged, then we have to worry about the worst," Anwar Gargash, a presidential advisor in the United Arab Emirates, said in an address at the summit.

Gargash added that it's not in the interest of the regional countries or Iran to go through another round of war.

"While we're going through this period of protracted crisis of no war, no peace, we are clearly seeking a political off-ramp," he said.

In his address, Egyptian Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty said, "We have to push very hard in order to prevent the escalation."

Noting that more fighting would affect food and energy security, he added, "The second round will be more

[See Mideast, A4]

$4 billion in Israel aid to be cut off

Trump says the annual monetary support is superfluous and a boon for Democrats. WORLD, A2

Utilities lobby for wildfire cost shield

California's power companies seek legislation to protect their shareholders.

By Melody Petersen

As a criminal investigation into Southern California Edison's actions before last year's deadly Eaton fire continues, the state's for-profit utilities are lobbying for legislation that would protect their shareholders from paying for future catastrophic fires they cause.

According to slides recently presented by a Pacific Gas & Electric executive to a group of state senators, the utilities are asking for a permanent cap to limit their

to pay the lion's share for fires utilities cause, there is no imperative for the for-profit utilities to take safety and fire mitigation seriously," said Jamie Court, president of Consumer Watchdog.

The utilities say their shareholders must be shielded from wildfire costs because the risk of future fires has damaged their credit ratings. Lower credit ratings mean the companies must pay higher interest rates on borrowing, an increased cost that gets passed on to electricity customers.

"It is in our customers' interest to have action in 2026," Pedro Pizarro, chief executive of Edison International, told Wall Street analysts last week when asked

A pitfall of new ADUs: Loss of parking

Push to build more housing creates a burden for car-reliant

With her cane, Tracey Ellis can just manage the 20-foot walk from her apart-

creasing number of landlords are converting parking spaces and garages into accessory dwelling units under

Great expectations for the next L.A. mayor

[Mayor, from A1]
block city sidewalks.

Over the last four years, L.A. budgeted about $4 billion to address homelessness — about $100,000 for every homeless person in the city, according to Lee Ohanian, a professor of economics at UCLA.

But the city has not spent all that money. L.A. underspent its homelessness budget by at least $473 million in the 2025-26 fiscal year, L.A. City Controller Kenneth Mejia said, because of its decentralized approach to homelessness, budget structure, staffing shortages and long approval delays for affordable housing.

Part of the challenge in addressing homelessness is that L.A. adopts a fragmented approach, sharing responsibility with the county and spreading programs among different nonprofits, said Fernando Guerra, founding director of the Center for the Study of Los Angeles at Loyola Marymount University. Unlike in New York, the L.A. mayor does not oversee the health department, mental health and drug recovery programs, and jails.

"The challenge for the mayor has always been that she or he is only given basically half of the arsenal to fight homelessness," Guerra said.

Poor oversight is also a problem. Federal prosecutors have charged multiple nonprofit leaders with defrauding taxpayer funds meant to support the homeless. Last month, a nonprofit chief executive pleaded guilty to wire fraud and embezzling $23 million in homeless funds to pay for a $7-million Westwood home and vacation property in Greece.

But perhaps the biggest challenge is the staggering cost of building housing for homeless people in L.A.. Because of complex government financing, prevailing wage requirements, environmental rules, and the integration of medical and social services, a single unit in L.A. can cost as much as $600,000.



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

INCUMBENT Karen Bass attends a mayoral campaign event at Homegirl Cafe in Chinatown on Monday.



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

CHALLENGER Nithya Raman sports an "I Voted" sticker after casting her ballot in Silver Lake on Tuesday.

Affordability

Nearly 6 out of 10 renters in L.A. are cost-burdened, and polls show a majority of L.A. voters have considered leaving the city because housing is so expensive.

Bass has taken steps to accelerate the building of affordable housing. Her signature program, Executive Directive One, succeeded in cutting the time it takes to review 100% affordable projects and led to a flurry of development proposals. But after tenant advocates warned that rent-controlled apartments would be demolished and homeowners complained that density threatened historic neighborhoods, Bass restricted the locations eligible for the program.

Developers are not exactly seeing a building boom. Last month, the mayor's office said more than 47,000 units of affordable housing are in the pipeline, but only 7,728 are under construction.

As with homelessness, the mayor has limited power to improve affordability.

A big test for the new mayor will be the state's push to pass laws that spur more housing, such as state Senate Bill 79, designed to accelerate development around transportation hubs. With new buildings likely to face opposition in many parts of the city, Bass has opposed SB 79, arguing that it will erode local control.

The next mayor will have to balance the need to build significantly more housing with homeowner opposition to new development, said Christian Grose, a professor of political science and public policy at USC.

"Voters probably are somewhere in the middle," Grose said, "and there doesn't seem to be a policy agenda that reaches those voters."

Infrastructure

When Chief Deputy City Controller Rick Cole retired from City Hall last year, he complained that "mind-numbing bureaucracy" had made the city ungovernable. Los Angeles was paying for city leaders' decision long ago to organize the city to disperse authority, he said, citing deteriorating infrastructure as a key example.

"Beneath the broken sidewalks," Cole said, "is a broken system."

More than 5,000 requests for sidewalk repairs are pending. Tens of thousands of streetlights are out. Last year, the city stopped repaving streets for eight months as officials struggled with staffing shortages to meet federal requirements to construct curb ramps for wheelchairs and new city rules that mandate bike, bus and pedestrian enhancements.

"The city can't seem to manage the basics," Bass' challenger, City Councilwoman Nithya Raman, said when she announced her campaign in February.

Guerra said it was astounding that such a large city government — with a $14.8-billion budget and more than 5,500 public works employees — was so behind on fixing streetlights and resurfacing roads.

"How could that be?" Guerra said. "You cannot tell us that you need more people and more money to do this. What is happening?"

To speed up infrastructure repairs, some public officials are urging voters to pass Measure LA, which would require the city to develop a long-term capital infrastructure plan and distribute more power to the director of public works. Supporters say the measure would cut systemic bureaucracy and fragmentation. Critics, however, say it would lead to one person holding too much authority.

Unstable city budget

Last year, the City Council and mayor declared a fiscal state of emergency as they faced a $1-billion deficit due to revenue shortfalls as well as increased liabilities from the Palisades fire. Rating agencies, including Standard & Poor's and Kroll, downgraded the city to a "negative" outlook.

Mejia cited ongoing revenue shortfalls, liability payouts and departmental overspending as the key reasons for the ballooning budget, which has grown by about 25% over the last four years.

The Bass administration has increased pay and benefits to thousands of city employees and police officers. It has also had to hand out record liability settlement payments due to LAPD excessive force claims and dangerous street and transport conditions.

Raman, a democratic socialist, has frequently voted against high city spending, opposing pay raises negotiated by Bass for Los Angeles Police Department officers and the $2.6-billion expansion of the Los Angeles Convention Center.

"She's the one that says, 'We cannot afford that. How are you going to pay for that?' " Guerra said of Raman. "It's very, very strange that the socialist is the fiscal hawk."

Police reform

Violent crime in L.A. has plummeted. Last month, Bass announced a 47% drop in homicides since she took office, and she has also touted a decline in property crimes such as burglaries.

But police reform and police pay remain issues. While Raman has reversed her past stance on defunding the police, she has stated she would replace LAPD Chief Jim McDonnell, who she says has "lost the confidence" of Angelenos on the issue of immigration. The city, she says, needs a police chief who ensures officers do not cooperate with federal immigration agents. She has vowed to conduct an audit of the department to determine whether there are gaps between Los Angeles' "sanctuary city" policies and police practices.

Bass has publicly backed McDonnell, supporting his efforts to stem officer attrition and rebuild the department's ranks. The department would be significantly disrupted, she has argued, if the chief were removed before the 2028 Olympic Games.

City Hall credibility

The new mayor will also face a challenge that is harder to qualify: making residents believe City Hall can fix Los Angeles' many problems.

"I think we're beyond pessimism in some places," Hogen-Esch said, noting that for the first time in a quarter-century he has spotted no mayoral campaign signs in his El Sereno neighborhood.

When it comes to homelessness, Angelenos would be happy to spend money if it actually solved the problem, said Jim Newton, a veteran journalist and editor of UCLA Blueprint magazine. Most want encampments gone for good, and not by locking people up or punishing them for being poor, but by genuinely helping them to be better.

"Is that possible?" he said. "I don't know."

Others say it will take new ideas and big swings that can be challenging in a city where the mayor has only limited powers.

City leaders today, Guerra said, "not only lack creativity and innovation in Los Angeles, but compared to other city governments, they're laggard in implementing new ideas."

Feds deploy late surge of election monitors to L.A.

[Monitors, from A1]

"They're not doing this to make sure that there are free and fair elections," said Eric J. Segall, a law professor at Georgia State University

the move. "It's unlawful and serves the plain purpose of intimidating voters."

The remaining monitors deployed by the Justice Department were directed to

Supreme Court," 9th Circuit Chief Judge Mary Helen Murguia wrote in her dissent to the initial 2-1 ruling, which appeared just after 8 p.m. Monday.

"The district court prop-

generally have the authority to enter an injunction prohibiting the Department of Justice from expressing its views about criminal statutes, even if the court determines that those views are

mands and violate their duties under state law.

The back-and-forth marked the latest dramatic twist in what had been a months-long effort by the Justice Department to claw back ballots it claims may

"In the lead-up to the election, high-ranking DOJ and DHS officials have engaged in a campaign to intimidate, threaten, and coerce state and local officials and employees who are engaged in administering the

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Los Angeles Times

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Campaign season of surprises is coming to a peak

Eventful twists create a chance Democrats could win House and maybe the Senate too.

By Justine McDaniel

WASHINGTON — An acutely contentious and historically expensive midterm campaign barrels to a finish Monday, on the eve of elections that will set the nation's course for the remaining half of President Trump's second term.

Republicans are bracing for a backlash from voters as Democrats prepare for gains — but the magnitude of any "blue wave," and whether it could sweep not only the U.S. House but also the Senate into Democratic control, will be the key question as Americans finish casting ballots Tuesday.

Early voting had already seen strong turnout, including among influence blocs such as Latino and Black voters. Candidates spent the weekend crisscrossing their states and pulling in surrogates to make a final push for voters still on the fence.

Capping a turbulent first half of Trump's second term, the campaign has been defined by affordability and economic issues that have created headwinds for Republicans and spurred a possible turn toward Democrats by voters. And as Trump has pushed the limits of executive power, the midterms could act as a consequential check on his presidential reach.

In recent polls, voters have consistently put Democrats several points ahead on the generic ballot and

[See **Surprises**, A6]

Endorsement stuns Democrats

Democrat Haley Stevens backs Republican Mike Rogers in the Michigan Senate race. **NATION, A3**



Carlin Stiehl For The Times



David Butow For The Times

DEMOCRAT Xavier Becerra, top, meets supporters in Irvine while Republican Steve Hilton wears a mask of his rival on Halloween in Highland Park.

Governor hopefuls barnstorm in final push

Becerra, Hilton trade barbs as they crisscross the state to drum up support in the last stretch

By Seema Mehta and Nicole Nixon

Donning a creepy mask of Democratic rival Xavier Becerra, Republican gubernatorial candidate Steve Hilton dashed around a children's Halloween event dishing out candy and warnings about potential liberal tax policies.

"Vote for Becerra, and your parents will have to pay every mile they drive. Isn't that great?" Hilton sarcastically said at a trunk or treat gathering Saturday in Highland Park. "These children are very pricey because if their parents vote for Becerra, they will be taxed every mile they drive. Yay! Yay! Mileage tax! Mileage tax! Mileage tax!"

Becerra was not spooked when he heard of Hilton's get-up and put-down.

"I suspect, if he takes off that mask, you'll see Donald Trump right underneath," Becerra, a former congressman, state attorney general and member of President Biden's Cabinet, said at a campaign event in Sacramento on Saturday. "That's who he really is. Either that or he's a clown."

With Tuesday's election barreling toward them, Becerra and Hilton traded barbs and did their best to gin up support as they crisscrossed California in what has been a relatively sedate

[See **Governor**, A7]

Bass, Raman took different paths to meet the moment

Incumbent and L.A. native is in a tight battle with immigrant rival in mayor's race.

By Noah Goldberg

When Karen Bass was first elected to the California state Assembly in 2004, Nithya Raman was halfway across the world, fresh out of college and working in the slums of Delhi, India.

Raman had visited Los Angeles for the first time only a year before. Bass, meanwhile, had already called L.A. home for more than half a century as she built a career as a physician's assistant, then as an activist, and finally as a politician.

The two women who have charted vastly different life paths are now locked in a contentious battle for mayor of Los Angeles. When the votes are finally tallied after election day Tuesday, the job will go to one of them: Bass, a daughter of South L.A. and the civil rights movement who committed her life to public service, or Raman, who moved to Los Angeles 13 years ago with her husband, hoping, like so many before them, to discover whatever their future might be.

Raman's relative newness to the city has become a talking point on the campaign trail for the Bass campaign and the mayor's surrogates, who have painted the challenger as ignorant of the city's sometimes painful past, including hammering Raman over a seemingly positive remark she made about former Police Chief Daryl F. Gates, who led the force during the 1991 videotaped police beating of Rodney King.

"It's one thing to be new. That's the secondary issue," Bass said in an interview with The Times. "But if you want to lead the city, you would think that you would know some of the most important moments in L.A. history."

Raman's response: Los Angeles was built by people like herself who came here seeking a better life and new opportunities.

"This city welcomed me with open arms. So when the mayor keeps saying I'm not really an Angeleno, she's attacking more than me. She's rejecting the very DNA of Los Angeles: a city where people from everywhere can find a place to belong and to build a dream," Raman said in a statement.

Karen Ruth Bass was born in South L.A. in 1953, though her family moved to the Fairfax District when she was young.

She grew up a news junkie, watching and listening to the news with her father during the civil rights movement, seeing how difficult integration was in the South.

As she watched the Rev. Martin Luther King Jr. fight racial discrimination in the South, Bass witnessed whites abandoning the Fairfax District as Black families moved in.

"The white neighbors moved so fast I never met them," she said. "I don't know if there's a word faster than flight."

At 14, Bass signed up her mother to be the precinct

[See **Mayor**, A6]

Candidates sprint to the finish line

Bass and Raman take veiled shots at each other as they crisscross L.A. to campaign. **CALIFORNIA, B3**

Fewer child-care options, soaring costs

Parents face pricier alternatives as UCLA and Samuel Goldwyn facilities plan to close.

By Emily Woodruff

Jillian Griffith had just gotten her 21-month-old to sleep and was sitting down for a story with her 4-year-old when she glanced at her phone and saw an urgent email from preschool. An enormous problem had just landed in her lap.

On Nov. 20, the 35-year-old Samuel Goldwyn Foundation Children's Center would close, the email said. Its operators blamed Hollywood's downturn and the flight of 4-year-olds to California's free transitional kindergarten programs.

Griffith's household budget had already felt the sting of the industry's troubles as her husband, a TV writer, weathered the strike. Now they would also have to find a new preschool in a shrinking and exorbitantly priced market.

Voices **PATT MORRISON** COLUMNIST

California has a rich history of reining in the uber-wealthy

The billionaire tax proposal is just the latest example of regular folks pushing back on the 1%

The New Testament has a lot to say about the poor, but it is short and not very sweet on how tricky it is for the rich to get into heaven.

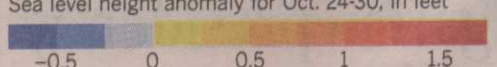
California, however, has proved to be a heaven on Earth for big-league moneymakers — billion-

El Niño worst-case scenario appearing more plausible

Last week's flooding is just a preview, experts say

Swollen seas

Sea levels on the California coast were more than 1 foot higher than would be expected due to a hotter ocean — influenced by El Niño-fueled Kelvin waves coming up from the equator.



By Rong-Gong Lin II and Sean Greene

The significant coastal flooding that hit Southern California in recent days points to what a worst-case scenario would look like in an El Niño-fueled winter with sea levels expected to rise even higher.

Last week's flooding was so bad because of two events

Different paths taken by candidates Bass, Raman

[Mayor, from A1]
leader to campaign for Robert F. Kennedy in the 1968 Democratic primary for president. Bass, instead of her mother, walked the streets and knocked on doors.

She was supposed to be at the Ambassador Hotel the night of Kennedy's assassination, she said, but her parents made her go to bed because she had school in the morning.

"I was in my bedroom, listening to the radio. I was excited and I heard the whole thing happen and it was a devastating milestone in my life," she said.

The killing left her disaffected with electoral politics, and she pivoted to activism and community politics.

An appreciation for Los Angeles

Nithya Varsha Raman was born in 1981 in Kerala, India, to a family without much money, she said, with her maternal grandparents providing most of her early care.

At 6, Raman and her mother left for the United States on a Pan Am flight, meeting her father who was already here studying engineering. The family put down roots in Burlington, Mass., a Boston suburb.

Her childhood was far less steeped in politics than Bass' was, but as an Indian girl in a town whose racial demographics were quickly shifting as more South Asians moved in, racial politics bled into her young life. The family lived along Route 128, "a superhighway of tech," according to Raman's best childhood friend, Nadia Salim, that became a suburban destination for many South Asians.

"The kids at school were not always super nice to us kids from immigrant families," said Salim. "For her, it sharpened some sense of empathy and curiosity about people."

Salim said she and Raman were spit on and called racial slurs.

"My reaction to that stuff was basically to try to disappear," Salim said. "I remember Nithya being very resistant. ... It didn't change her behavior."

"The experience that I had growing up makes me appreciate Los Angeles so much," Raman said in an interview.

Bass 'quietly did the work' behind scenes

Bass graduated from Alexander Hamilton High School in West Los Angeles and went to college at San Diego State University from 1971 to 1973, eventually graduating from the physician assistant program at USC Keck School of Medicine. She also earned a bachelor of science in health sciences from Cal State Dominguez Hills in 1990.

In 1973, Bass visited Cuba with the Venceremos Brigade, a U.S.-Cuba solidarity project. She had already been interested in socialism during a post-high school trip to what was then Yugoslavia.

She built houses and listened to speakers in Cuba.

"I was in search for a society where there was equality, where basics were covered, and I didn't understand why that couldn't happen in my own country," Bass said.

As a young adult, Bass began working as a physician assistant at Children's Hospital and other facilities.

"My day job was in hospitals, but in the evening, I was active on police reform and other issues that were taking place in my neighborhood," Bass said.

Antonio Villaraigosa, the former mayor of Los Angeles, met Bass in the 1970s, when both were left-wing community organizers participating in the Coalition Against Police Abuse.

"She quietly did the work," he said. "She didn't give big speeches. I was giving big speeches. She wasn't that person. She was the person that, behind the scenes, did all the work. Smart, tough, serious."

Bass created Community Coalition in 1990, feeling it was imperative to intervene in the crack cocaine epidemic that was plaguing South L.A.

"So many Black people were dying from crack, AIDS and violence," she said. "So many Black families who were in line to move up in class status fell back, because people got addicted to crack."

Bass gathered her progressive friends in her living room and pitched Community Coalition to fight the crisis she saw on the streets.

"Half of them supported me, half of them thought, 'No, we can't do anything. We need socialism first,' " Bass said. "I said, 'People are dying. I'm going to do whatever the hell I need to do to save people's lives,' and that's what I set out to do."

'I was so shocked by the scale of it'

Raman attended Harvard University, where she met her future husband, Vali Chandrasekaran, graduating in 2003 with a degree in social studies.

Like Bass, Raman also went abroad after college, but in her case the destination was Delhi.

"I didn't have a lot of sense of what I wanted to do in the future. No grand plan," Raman said.

Shortly after she arrived, more than 100,000 people were evicted from slums on the Yamuna River.

"I was so shocked by the scale of it," she said. "It felt crazily large and unjust and I wanted to get involved."

Raman began working with slum dwellers' organizations in Delhi, first trying to stop the evictions and later documenting conditions in the resettlement colonies, pushing for running water and better sanitation.

From Delhi, she moved south to Chennai, where she pursued similar work on slum dwellers' rights. She returned to the U.S. to get her master's degree in urban planning at MIT, graduating in 2008.



RICH PEDRONCELLI Associated Press



MEL MELCON Los Angeles Times

ASSEMBLYMEMBER Karen Bass, top center, listens to Speaker Fabian Núñez in 2007. Nithya Raman, above left, with her City Council campaign staff in 2020.

She moved back to Chennai after school and started a nonprofit, Transparent Chennai, in 2010. She and her co-founders tried to get the city to invest in sanitation for unmapped slums using data. They mapped out public toilets in some of the poorest regions of the city, created bus route databases and fought slum clearance policies.

"It was all following the bug of, like, how do we make cities meet their promise?" Raman said of their work.

Raman married Chandrasekaran, who by then was an up-and-coming TV writer, in 2010. In 2013, she left Chennai and moved to L.A.

From an organizer to a rising politician

Bass ran for the California state Assembly as a Democrat in 2004, making the jump from community organizer to elected official representing a district that spanned parts of South and West Los Angeles.

She said she found the transition easy because she went to Sacramento with an agenda to further the work she had been pursuing in South L.A. She toiled on criminal justice reform, specifically helping incarcerated people transition back into the community.

In her final term, her colleagues elected Bass as Assembly speaker, the second-most powerful job in Sacramento after the governor.

"She has that way about her that really is empathetic and persuasive," said Fabian Núñez, who preceded her as speaker.

Bass led the Assembly through the 2008-09 financial crisis.

"I went up [to Sacramento] to expand these programs and wound up having to cut them. And that was very, very painful, but it's what I had to do so that the state of California did not default," she said.

In 2010, Bass ran for Congress, ultimately serving six terms. In Washington, she cemented her reputation as a liberal who was not afraid to work across the aisle with people she disagreed with to try to find common ground and pass legislation.

Bass said she still talks with Republican former House Speaker Kevin McCarthy of Bakersfield, whom she has considered a friend for 20 years.

"I've always been about building coalitions, keeping my eyes on the prize, working with people who disagree with me, working with people who don't like me," Bass said.

Finding her footing after L.A. arrival

Raman's early days in L.A. were filled with uncertainty.

"It takes a little while to find a foothold here," she said.

She eventually landed a gig as a management trainee at the city administrative officer's office, writing a 2015 report on how Los Angeles was dealing with a burgeoning homeless crisis.

"A lot of money was being spent on addressing the impacts of homelessness ... without addressing why people were on the streets in the first place," Raman said.

She began talking with neighbors about starting an organization to serve the homeless, and in 2017 started the SELAH Neighborhood Homeless Coalition, its name an acronym for the communities it serves: Silver Lake, Echo Park, Los Feliz, Atwater Village and Hollywood.

"She was 8½ months pregnant when I met her. She said, 'I want to end homelessness in L.A.' I was like, 'Girl, you can barely get up the stairs,' " said Dori Dowler-Guerrero, a co-founder of SELAH.

Dowler-Guerrero said Raman had an uncanny ability to get people organized and always had an unwavering belief in her own ability to get things done.

Raman decided to challenge Councilmember David Ryu for reelection in 2020, becoming the first candidate in 17 years to unseat an incumbent City Council member. She had lived in L.A. less than a decade.

Much of her work since joining the council has been geared around something homelessness advocate Mollie Lowery told her when they first met: "Whatever it takes for as long as it takes."

Raman has had the quote written on the chalkboard in her kitchen for about a decade.

Bass and Raman on collision course

After 12 years in Congress — and making the short list as a potential running mate for Joe Biden in 2020 — Bass ran for L.A. mayor in 2022. Her election completed her career's arc that began locally, then expanded to California, then the nation and finally returned home.

"What I have so enjoyed about this job is my life has come full circle," Bass said, adding that whether she wins or loses, this will be her last election. "These are issues I've been working on for the last 30-plus years."

She was endorsed in 2022 by Raman and returned the favor when Raman ran for reelection to the council in 2024.

The two were considered allies who shared homelessness as their top concern in the city, with Bass leading from her executive office and Raman chairing the City Council's Housing and Homelessness Committee.

Whatever friendship the two shared was shattered Feb. 7, when Raman announced her last-minute bid for mayor, saying that Bass had failed to deliver on reducing high housing costs, fixing broken streetlights and adequately addressing the homelessness crisis.

Their two paths to power — which led them on vastly different journeys through different countries, organizations and governmental roles — left them on a collision course to lead Los Angeles.

Bass said she and Raman share no similarities in where they come from.

"I don't think there's anything similar about our paths," she said.

Raman said that their diverging paths don't matter, and that Angelenos don't care about where you come from.

"Part of what makes L.A. so incredible is the fact that it doesn't ask you about who you are, where you're from," Raman said. "It just asks you about your work and what you want to do."

Both women want to be mayor, and Tuesday's election will determine which path forward Los Angeles voters want to take.

For midterm vote results, prepare 'to buckle up and wait'

[Surprises, from A1]
given a historically low approval rating to Trump.

Eyes are now on Senate control, as an unexpected competitiveness by Democrats in a handful of red states has put the majority

tive races will not only set the dynamic between Trump and Congress for the next two years, but also hold signs for the 2028 presidential campaign. Both parties are closely watching how well Democrats can do



has also drawn attention with off-script comments at his rallies about GOP candidates' rear ends and for lashing out at a reporter who asked why he had canceled his final two rallies, which

right, voting's not so bad,' " Waithe said. "There's no pressure. ... We're not telling you which party to vote for or which candidate. We're just like, 'Thank you for partici-

Gubernato

[Governor, from A1]
race to succeed Democrat Gavin Newsom, who is wrapping up his final term as governor. Recent polls show Becerra leading Hilton by at least 20 percentage points, which is not a surprise in a state where Democratic voters vastly outnumber Republicans and GOP candidates last won a statewide election two decades ago.

Becerra has spent the waning days of the campaign stumping for Democrats in competitive House races in the Central Valley and Southern California.

On Sunday afternoon, Becerra stumped for Reps. Dave Min (D-Irvine) and Derek Tran (D-Orange) alongside Newsom.

"I'm so grateful to our current and future governor for being here, passing the baton," Min said at a rally in Irvine, where both he and Becerra referred to Newsom as a future president. "We are living in a historic moment, one that everyone's going to look back [at and] ask, 'What did we do at this moment when America was in crisis, when our democracy was in crisis?' "

Newsom said that the state's voters could have lamented about the unfairness of Trump's attempts to gerrymander districts in GOP-led states to boost his party's ability to keep control of Congress, but that Californians instead responded by redrawing their congressional boundaries last year.

"Donald Trump does not believe in the rule of law. He believes in the rule of Don," Newsom said. "And I hope it's [clear to] everyone across this region and this state how precious this moment is, and how important all of you are to meet this moment. Let's not run the 90-yard dash."

Party leaders are trying to capitalize on broad anti-Trump sentiment to juice the state's liberal electorate and win in House districts that were redrawn to favor Democrats, including a Sacramento-area seat currently held by Republican-turned-independent Rep. Kevin Kiley.

"We're not just gonna take back these seats in California. We're gonna take back the House and the Senate," Becerra told costumed and cheering volunteers during a quick Saturday stop in support of Richard Pan, the Democrat challenging Kiley. Trump, Becerra said, wants to "destroy democracy. That's why we're getting out to vote."

The Republican president is a big motivator for Democrats this

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turned 65, moved, or
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Los Angeles Times

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SATURDAY, OCTOBER 31, 2026

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MARIO TAMA Getty Images

DEMAND for AI infrastructure is fueling a boom in data centers, including this one being built in Vernon.

Request to block 20,000 ballots is again rejected

Appellate ruling calls bid unconstitutional. Federal case may go to Supreme Court.

BY KEVIN RECTOR AND BRITTNY MEJIA

A federal appeals court for the second time Friday denied a Trump administration request to block 20,000 ballots from California voters the administration alleges may be noncitizens — ruling that the administration had failed to show that "such extraordinary relief, during an ongoing election, is clearly required by law."

Trump administration officials did not immediately respond to a request for comment, including on whether it will appeal to the U.S. Supreme Court.

The three-judge panel of the U.S. 9th Circuit Court of Appeals — composed of two appointees of President Trump and one of President Biden — ruled 2-1 that the U.S. Constitution gives the state and Congress the power to decide how elections are run, and that allowing the Trump administration to "misuse" federal statutes to "prescribe" how California must process ballots would "override the plain and manifest dictates of the Constitution itself."

"Because Congress has not exercised the specific power granted to it under

[See **Ballots,** A8]

What subpoenas may mean in L.A.

The DOJ's move could hint at criminal charges, but election officials can fight back. **NATION, A6**

Big Tech stocks drop amid AI sell-offs

Investors begin to question whether the massive spending will pay off soon.

BY QUEENIE WONG

Many of the top technology stocks, which seemed almost unstoppable for months, got hammered this week as fears grew that massive spending on artificial intelligence won't pay off anytime soon.

Some investors have expressed concerns that the AI rally has inflated some shares too much. Hundreds of billions of dollars are being spent on data centers and the research to build and test the powerful large language models behind AI, but it remains uncertain whether future profits will justify the investment.

Companies have yet to prove they have enough customers for the technology and, at the same time, have expressed the need to slow down the pace of development to ensure it can be safely managed.

The latest quarterly results confirmed many concerns: While high AI profits are still far off, much more spending is still required. Many investors have taken this moment to sell some of their tech shares as they wait for a clearer outlook on profits and spending.

Meanwhile, many tech companies are realizing that AI could shift customers away from other parts of their business that are more profitable.

"The disruption caused by AI is on full display during tech earnings and the uncertainty around which names

L.A.'s Black leaders wary of Bass' prospects

To fend off Raman, mayor must shore up core support by driving up turnout on her home turf

BY DAVID ZAHNISER

It was a sprawling street festival in the cultural heart of Black Los Angeles, and Mayor Karen Bass was making her campaign pitch again and again.

Standing on a stage spanning the width of Crenshaw Boulevard, Bass urged the predominantly Black audience at the annual Taste of Soul gathering to send in their ballots, telling them about her roots in South L.A. and her crusade to reduce homelessness.

"I ran for mayor because I didn't want to see our people on the streets," said Bass, clutching the microphone in 90-degree mid-October heat. "We're only 9% of the city, and we're over 30% of the people in those tents."

Bass, the first Black woman to serve as Los Angeles mayor, is in the fight of her political career, facing a vigorous challenge from Councilmember Nithya Raman, who initially endorsed the mayor only to launch her own campaign at the eleventh hour. To win the race, Bass will need to drive up turnout among the city's Black voters and across her home turf in South Los Angeles.

The latest Berkeley Institute of Governmental Studies/L.A. Times poll found that Bass has closed an 11-point gap and is now in a dead heat with Raman. Yet the mayor continues to be dogged by stubbornly high disapproval numbers, leaving some of the city's Black civic leaders on edge about Bass' prospects — at a time when Black representation is already decreasing at City Hall.

[See **Mayor,** A9]



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

THE RULE applies to 600 active and 1,200 idle oil wells. Above, a pumpjack in L.A.

L.A. bans production of oil after years-long fight

Ordinance ends new drilling, phases out active wells



RONALDO BOLAÑOS Los Angeles Times

AN OPEN voting machine is shown at Arroyo Seco Regional Branch Library in Highland Park this week.

Feeble Congress now faces its voters

This group has passed fewer bills, done less oversight than others in modern history.

BY MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Next week's elections are widely seen as a referendum on President Trump, his team and his party, with most voters telling pollsters they seek a check on his power. But the midterms will also serve as a reckoning for one of the least productive sessions of Congress in a century.

A stunningly low 10% of Americans approve of the job performance of Congress, which has passed fewer bills and conducted less oversight than any of its predecessors in modern history, according to scholars of the legislative branch.

The biggest achievement of unified Republican control has also become one of its biggest liabilities. Deeply unpopular when signed, the One Big Beautiful Bill Act has only grown more controversial, with most Americans still unclear on what's in it — and those who do know largely disapproving of the law, which cut taxes for businesses and billionaires while adding trillions to the national debt.

A summer Politico poll found that just 8% of Americans believe the law has improved their bottom line. The bill cut billions of dollars for food stamps and over a trillion in health programs and Medicaid.

Two other significant bills passed by this Congress — the Epstein Files Transparency Act and a housing reform package targeting corporate purchases of single-family homes — ultimately became law over Trump's opposition, leaving Republicans little credit for bipartisan wins.

"It's not a partisan statement to say that the current Congress will go down in his-

[See **Congress,** A8]

It's a grudge rematch

Bass has been leaning hard on South L.A. roots

[Mayor, from A1]

City Councilmember Curren Price, who is also Black, steps down at the end of the year — and regardless of the election's outcome, his successor will be Latino. That will leave the council with two Black members out of 15 for the first time since 1963, not counting temporary vacancies, according to archivists in the city clerk's office.

Karim Webb, who served until February as one of Bass' airport commissioners, said it's been painful to see the mayor in such a vulnerable spot. The unease felt in the community is not simply because Bass is Black, he said, but because she has spent her whole life fighting for South L.A., especially the people there who are living on the margins.

"To have a Black woman champion, a native Angeleno who's been involved in politics since high school, potentially taken out in this way — it's heartbreaking. It's angering. It's how a lot of us feel about America," said Webb, a principal with the firm Webb Investments.

City Council President Marqueece Harris-Dawson, a friend and ally of Bass since 1995 who is Black, said Black Angelenos have benefited from the mayor's work on public safety, economic development and construction of affordable housing.

Homicides have been cut in half citywide and long-neglected commercial corridors, including Crenshaw Boulevard, have seen a burst of new construction, said Harris-Dawson, whose district is about one-third Black.

"Having someone in the mayor's office who's familiar with our neighborhoods and thinks about our neighborhoods makes a significant difference," he said.

Raman, a rising political star backed by the Democratic Socialists of America, has built up a huge advantage in and near her own home turf — neighborhoods such as Silver Lake, Echo Park and Highland Park. But she's been campaigning for Black votes as well, recently issuing a policy paper promising to protect renters and champion "reparative policies that help Black families build and preserve wealth."



JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

MAYOR Karen Bass with volunteers at her Baldwin Hills election headquarters.

Like Bass, Raman showed up at Taste of Soul, the mile-long street festival on Crenshaw. She headed over to a booth run by the Western States Regional Council of Carpenters, which is spending more than $10 million to promote her campaign, where workers were handing out Raman lapel buttons — not always successfully.

Raman, a Silver Lake resident, picked up the endorsement of the Black Los Angeles Young Democrats, which criticized Bass over the support her bid for reelection has received from the city's police union, which has spent heavily on ads attacking Raman.

Raman has also won the backing of Melina Abdullah, co-founder of Black Lives Matter Los Angeles, which has long pushed for cuts to law enforcement spending in L.A.

Abdullah said she cares deeply for Bass and considers her to be a longtime friend. But she praised Raman for promising to remove Police Chief Jim McDonnell, saying such a move is needed to address a surge in police shootings and expensive legal payouts by the Los Angeles Police Department.

"Nithya has also been willing to listen to and engage community members on key issues, rather than digging her heels in to advance special interests," she said.

Those types of sentiments have been echoed by younger voters. Efa Akutekha, a 35-year-old digital marketing producer with about 20,000 followers on TikTok, praised Raman's work strengthening the city's tenant protections and pushing for an expansion of L.A.'s unarmed crisis response teams.

Although both candidates support such efforts, Bass has also called for an increase in the number of police officers. Raman said she wants to keep the force at current levels.

"I don't think that expanding the LAPD is the main thing we need to focus on in terms of public safety," said Akutekha, who lives in Mid-City.

Bass continues to hold a commanding lead among likely Black voters, who favor her over Raman by a 71% to 13% margin, according to the Berkeley IGS/L.A. Times poll.

Bass won her first race for mayor in 2022, at an explosive moment for race relations in L.A. During the final weeks of the campaign, audio surfaced of a conversation among three Latino council members and a high-level labor leader that featured racist and derogatory remarks. In the wake of that scandal, which sparked weeks of protests, some argued that Bass would be a healing force at City Hall.

This time around, Bass has been leaning hard on her South L.A. roots, telling audiences she spent her early childhood at 49th and Central Avenue, a neighborhood that once bustled with Black hotels, nightclubs and other businesses. She has talked about her work forming and then running Community Coalition, which worked to help South L.A. recover in the wake of the 1992 riots that broke out after four police officers were acquitted in the beating of Black motorist Rodney King.

Bass has issued withering critiques of Raman, portraying her as uninformed about Black voters and their history in the city.

Two weeks ago, the mayor seized on remarks made by Raman during an NBC4/Telemundo 52 debate. During that hourlong event, Raman said the LAPD under former Police Chief Daryl F. Gates was the "gold standard" for its noncooperation with federal immigration agencies.

Days later, Bass and other Black leaders gathered at her campaign headquarters to demand an apology from Raman, saying she was glorifying the Gates era, when many Black and Latino residents suffered abuse at the hands of police.

"She has no history and no experience with the city," Bass declared. "Otherwise she would have remembered Rodney King, she would have remembered 1992, and she would have never put Daryl Gates in her mouth."

Before the event ended, Raman had uploaded a video to Youtube accusing Bass of deliberately twisting her words. She said she viewed Gates as a racist and was only speaking about Special Order 40, which was issued by Gates in 1979, barring officers from stopping people for the sole purpose of determining their immigration status.

Days later, Raman began apologizing, acknowledging to CNN that the mention of the former chief's name "causes real pain" for many in the city. "I should not have said it," she told the outlet.

Former City Councilmember Bernard C. Parks, who held office from 2003 to 2015, dismissed the criticism. A former police chief himself, he said it was clear from Raman's debate remarks that she was praising Special Order 40 and not Gates.

Parks, who is Black, has endorsed Raman. He said Bass has underperformed on homelessness, the Palisades fire and the city's soaring legal payouts. He also voiced dissatisfaction with the condition of the city's streets and sidewalks.

"Just drive down La Cienega," he said. "You almost need a new alignment on your car."

Bass has been working to rally her base in recent weeks, holding a get-out-the-vote rally last weekend at her campaign headquarters in Baldwin Hills attended by U.S. Rep. Sydney Kamlager-Dove (D-Los Angeles) and Councilmember Heather Hutt.

Trina Traylor, a manager with the Los Angeles Black Worker Center, showed up at that rally looking to donate her time. In an interview, she said she knocked on doors for Bass four years ago and believes that the mayor's work has made her neighborhood safer.

Traylor pointed to the mayor's Inside Safe initiative, which cleared a long-standing homeless encampment on Western Avenue at 88th Street, not far from her home.

"It used to be really filthy — nasty, stinky. There was a lot of drug activity. Now that it's clean we can walk down that street," said Traylor, who was speaking for herself, not her nonprofit. "I can walk my dogs now in my neighborhood."

L.A. County sheriff's race pits incumbent vs. predecessor

[Sheriff, from A1]

ale low, deputy jobs unfilled and criminals unpunished.

It's a stark clash between two very different personalities and platforms.

Candidates on the campaign trail

Villanueva showed up early at the Burbank Assn. of Realtors' event space on Magnolia Boulevard, with a stack of campaign signs under the arm of his brass-buttoned navy sports coat.

The former sheriff stood on a low stage and presented a vision of an L.A. County that was thriving when he left office nearly four years ago, but has since gone to the dogs on the back of ineffectual leadership and poor decisions.

After years of fiery appearances on Fox News and a sharp rightward turn that alienated some of his core Democratic supporters, Villanueva's demeanor with voters that September afternoon was disarmingly warm and casual. But his rhetoric hasn't softened. If anything, he has sharpened his message since the primary, escalating his claims about the chaos that will reign if Luna wins a second term.

Villanueva railed against Luna's homeless policies and disaster management capabilities. The former sheriff criticized his successor's response to the Palisades fire, saying he "failed to protect the people of Pacific Palisades."

"He's trying to make a difference. Nothing's done 100% perfect, but you know he is trying, and that's what we need. The streets are a lot safer."

— MIKE AGUILAR, at right in photo, after meeting Sheriff Robert Luna

Villanueva said Luna's failures trickle down to the troops on the ground," Rodriguez said. "Nobody wants to go to war with a general that is going to sit in the rear. ... I want one that'll go into war with me."

Minerva and Jose Corral of Corral Investments & Realty said they preferred most of Villanueva's policies over those of Luna, particularly around the Sheriff's Department's handling of evictions. Villanueva said he would work to streamline the process and beef up what he described as the "skeleton crew" dedicated to evictions.

But the Corrals also said they weren't convinced that returning the former sheriff to office was the solution.

"You remember when he was sheriff last time?" Minerva Corral said. "It was very combative. They were, like, brawling at Tuesday meetings."

Jose Corral quoted an old song by The Who to sum up his feelings about the race.

"Meet the new boss, same as the old boss," he said.

Villanueva had intended to participate in a planned tour of homeless encampments in downtown L.A. later in the day. But the air conditioning in his BMW had gone out on the way to Burbank, so the former sheriff decided to instead attempt what he called the "Hail Mary" feat of driving himself and his wife, Vivian, a retired





Photographs by GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

FORMER Sheriff Alex Villanueva, above, makes his pitch at a meeting of the Burbank Assn. of Realtors.

Both men led the county through historic calamities. Villanueva was sheriff when COVID-19 brought L.A. County to its knees in 2020; has been crippled under Luna by staffing shortfalls, budgetary mismanagement and lack of confidence.

Luna remains further

borhood without being recognized. As he waited for his food, several people asked to take pictures with him and shared their thoughts about his performance as sheriff.

Rafael Nolasco grew up in East Los Angeles, graduated from East Los Angeles College and still lives in the area. As a first-generation Mexican American and accountant from the same part of town as the sheriff, he's a bread-and-butter Luna supporter. So is Mike Aguilar, who also grew up in East Los Angeles and sports a Raiders tattoo on his forearm.

Both men see Luna as a role model for making so much of his humble beginnings, and also because of

new state law expanded oversight bodies' access to confidential records.

Villanueva claimed his opponent was delaying the records' release until after the election. Luna, citing the position of the county counsel, said his hands are tied while a "meet and confer" process plays out between Sheriff's Department unions and the county.

While Luna has at times locked horns with the Inspector General's office, the oversight commission and criminal justice reform groups, his tenure has been far less tumultuous than his predecessor's.

Villanueva defends unit he created

Villanueva initiated a criminal investigation of a Times reporter before walking it back amid widespread condemnation. He still defends the public corruption unit he created within the Sheriff's Department, despite concerns among government watchdogs that some of its actions — including an early morning raid in 2022 of the home of then-Supervisor Sheila Kuehl, a vocal critic of Villanueva — were politically motivated.

"We created a public corruption unit, and we did the very first investigation on what was nonprofit fraud, and th

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ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

floods the road, businesses and homes Tuesday along Pacific Coast Highway in Sunset Beach.

Trump's DOJ intensifies its war over voting

California's attorneys gear up for battle after L.A. County officials receive subpoenas.

BY KEVIN RECTOR AND BRITTNY MEJIA

Soon after a federal judge in Los Angeles sharply rejected a Trump administration effort to block 20,000 California ballots from voters it alleged may be noncitizens, the U.S. Justice Department appealed — leaving attorneys on both sides preparing Thursday for yet another court battle.

That was despite the lower-court judge calling the request an unlawful threat to eligible voters in Tuesday's midterm election and to free and fair American elections moving forward, and the same appellate court having already rejected the plan days before.

"Every day, more ballots are processed by election officials. This ongoing emergency disenfranchises American citizens through dilution," wrote First Assistant U.S. Atty. Bill Essayli, the lead prosecutor in L.A.

Early Thursday, Gov. Gavin Newsom swiped back at the Trump administration, writing, "A warning to Donald Trump: I'm deploying election lawyers to key battleground districts in California to protect every vote. And I just made it a FELONY to illegally seize ballots."

With just days to go until polls close, the heated election war between California and the Trump administration is showing no signs of slowing down despite multiple court orders rejecting the administration's central effort to interfere in the midterms by accusing state and county officials of willfully turning a blind eye to voter fraud.

That's in part because lawyers within the U.S. Justice Department have been unrelenting in their pursuit of such control, both through court orders and threats to state and county officials — including through criminal grand jury subpoenas issued to at least three officials in Los Angeles County Registrar-Recorder/County Clerk Dean Logan's office.

The subpoenas, reviewed

[See Fight, A6]

When election denialism is on ballot

Citizens groups are volunteering to guard against possible federal interference nationwide

BY JUSTINE MCDANIEL

CHANDLER, Ariz. — At balloon-adorned tables in red, white and blue, a handful of voters inside a church gymnasium listened as Medina Moore explained what to do if federal agents show up at the polls.

Call a hotline, she told volunteers, where attorneys will be ready to respond. Take videos, report what you see and remove yourself from any situation that becomes intense, she advised.

It was one of Moore's final poll monitor trainings in the Phoenix area before election day, preparing a few new "peacekeepers" to join the ranks of about 200 she has recruited from local faith groups in the Phoenix area to greet voters, answer questions and keep an eye out for problems at voting sites on Tuesday.

"It feels very urgent this year," said Moore, the voting rights organizer for the Arizona Faith Network, a coalition of religious groups. "We're in an era of information overload. Being able to educate voters on what's true and what's not is very important."

As lawyers nationwide prepare defenses against possible election interference by the Trump administration and election officials train for worst-case scenarios, ordinary citizens across the country are also readying to help. Through nonpartisan groups, parents are training to be poll monitors, law students are staffing legal hotlines, veterans are holding voting events and business owners are signing pledges to back local election officials.

The grassroots efforts, underpinned by various voting and democracy nonprofits, amount to a striking push by American voters to help uphold the nation's election system in the face of possible threats from its own government. More than 21,000 people nationwide have been trained as

[See Election, A6]

Becerra widens his strong lead in poll

Voters are mixed about significance of first elected Latino governor if he wins.

BY NICOLE NIXON

SACRAMENTO — Xavier Becerra is poised to make history as California's first elected Latino governor, according to a new poll.

But the survey shows voters, and Latinos in particular, have mixed views on the significance and impact of Becerra's probable win.

According to the poll by the UC Berkeley Institute of Governmental Studies and co-sponsored by the Los Angeles Times, the veteran Democratic politician was backed by 61% of likely California voters, compared with 34% who supported his Republican rival, former Fox News commentator Steve Hilton. That is slightly up from a September IGS survey that showed Becerra leading by 25 percentage points.

"He's solidified almost unanimous support now among Democrats," IGS Poll Director Mark DiCamillo said. "Republicans are almost unanimous in the other direction."

Becerra, a former U.S. Health and Human Services secretary, congressman and state attorney general, "hasn't offended any significant parts of the Democratic Party" and has united the party's voters by "hammering away" against President Trump, DiCamillo said.

When asked to name one or two top priorities for the election, 40% of likely voters chose pushing back against the Trump administration, followed by 34% who cited reducing the cost of living. It's a reversal from the mid-September survey, when 44% of likely voters said the cost of living was a top issue and 37% listed fighting Trump.

Both of those issues far outweighed the concerns of California voters about other issues that dominated the political discourse in

[See Governor, A8]

PATRICK STEWART, 1940 - 2026

All the universe was his stage

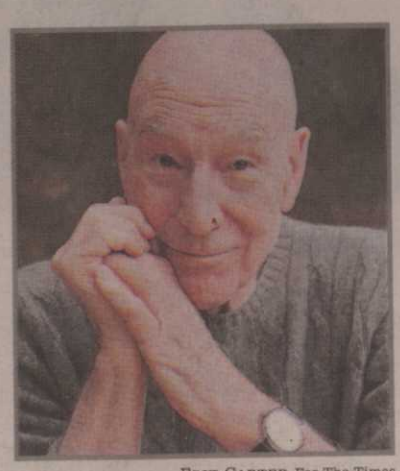
Shakespearean actor is best known for sci-fi roles

BY TRACY BROWN

Patrick Stewart, the British actor whose 60-year career spanned the stage to the final frontier, has died. He was 86.

Stewart died Wednesday at his home in Los Angeles from Alzheimer's disease and Lewy body dementia, his longtime spokesperson, Kelly Bush Novak, said in a statement.

A classically trained stage actor, Stewart was relatively unknown to American audiences when he was cast to lead a revival of "Star Trek." In addition to portraying Jean-Luc Picard in "Star Trek: The Next Generation" and numerous follow-ups, he is known for playing Professor Charles Xavier in the "X-Men" franchise and voicing Avery Bullock in the animated "Am



ERIK CARTER For The Times

BELOVED STAR
Patrick Stewart, shown at home in

Federal judge bars racial profiling by ICE agents

She cites a 'mountain

feat the mountain of evidence that, in practice, agents do not follow the law,"

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A 51786.72 ▼ 197.26 0.38% NASDAQ 25372.01 ▲ 0.8% STOXX 600 645.66 ▼ 0.6% 10-YR. TREAS. ▼ 14/32, yield 4.951% OIL $96.09 ▼ $0.37 GOLD $3,927.90 ▼ $29.00 EURO $1.1192 YEN 158.69

What's News

Business & Finance

U.S. stocks finished xed with trepidation ead of the midterm elec- n results, with the S&P 0 and Nasdaq rising 0.4% d 0.8%, respectively, and e Dow falling 0.4%. **B11**

Elliott Investment Manage- ent compared the current ate of the financial markets the Roaring '20s that pre- ded the Great Depression. **B1**

China told its biggest secu- ties firms and banks to throt- le back their work on IPOs nd focus on boosting the truggling stock market. **B2**

U.S. job openings rose to .5 million in September rom an upwardly revised 7.2 illion in August while hir- ng held relatively steady. **A2**

AMD's sales beat Wall Street's expectations, though deal it made last year with OpenAI weighed on its third- quarter net income. **B4**

Saudi Aramco reported a ise in third-quarter profit, of- ering some relief to the king- dom's finances during a pe- iod of escalating conflict with Yemen's Houthi militants. **B3**

Unilever aims to save the equivalent of about $1.12 bil- ion and secure steady sales growth as it focuses its usiness on a slimmer core f nonfood products. **B4**

Keurig Dr Pepper re- orted higher profit and ales for the latest quarter ven though its coffee busi- ess is taking longer than xpected to recover. **B3**

Ferrari again lifted its full-year guidance as de- mand for car customizations remained strong and deliver- es of newer models rose in he third quarter. **B3**

Worldwide

Millions of voters cast allots across the country as ntrol of Congress hung in e balance, with Democrats oping to regain majorities both chambers and usher a new era of divided gov- rnment during Trump's final wo years in office. **A1, A4-5**

Preliminary results from national survey showed any voters expressing dis- leasure about Trump's job erformance while voicing ngst about the cost of living nd the nation's direction. **A1**

Trump said the U.S. would ut off military aid to Israel y the end of the year, sug- esting the phaseout of such rants could occur much aster than expected. **A1**

Pieces of the tail of the usiness jet that crashed in lorida were found miles way from the impact site, ndicating part of the aircraft eparated while in the air. **A3**

A Russian airstrike killed at least 31 people, with nearly 50 more missing, at a school in southern Ukraine where humanitarian aid was being distributed. **A6**

NATO is developing a re- sponse doctrine that includes strikes far inside Russia should Moscow attack alli- ance members' territory. **A6**

Google said it would by

Control of Congress at Stake







CLOCKWISE FROM TOP LEFT: KEVIN LAMARQUE/REUTERS; EDGAR SU/REUTERS; MIKE SEGAR/REUTERS

Voters nationwide headed to polls Tuesday, clockwise from top left, in Portland, Maine, and Atlanta while students lined up to vote at the University of Texas in Austin. Scan the code to get the latest on the elections at WSJ.com.

Democrats hope a backlash to Trump will return them to power on Capitol Hill

Millions of voters cast ballots across the country on Tuesday as control of Congress hung in the balance, with Democrats hoping to regain majorities in both chambers and usher in a new era of divided government during President Trump's final two years in office.

By Eliza Collins, Sabrina Rodriguez and Ken Thomas

Heading into Tuesday, Democratic candidates were seen as competitive in seats previously considered safe bets for Republicans, including those that Trump won by double-digits in the 2024 presidential election. To flip the House, Democrats needed a net gain of three seats, and most election handicappers expected them to win at least a dozen more.

Control of the Senate, once considered a strong likelihood for the GOP, was up for grabs after candidates in ruby red states like Texas, Alaska, Ohio and Iowa were locked in tight races. To win a majority in the Senate, Democrats needed a net pickup of four seats across a campaign map full of Republican terrain.

Republican candidates have faced consistent backlash over Trump's governing, including complaints over inflation and the broader state of the economy. Voters were particularly frustrated with the president's use of tariffs, his launching of the Iran War and an aggressive deportation strategy.

Trump's approval rating fell to 37% in a September Wall Street Journal poll, the lowest of any president heading into midterms in Wall Street Journal polling dating to 1990.

"I'd characterize our mood as nauseously optimistic," Sen. Chuck Schumer of New York, the chamber's Democratic leader, said in Brooklyn

Please turn to page A4

Voters Bemoan State of Economy

By John McCormick And Anthony DeBarros

Two years after handing Republicans control of Washington, voters in Tuesday's election expressed displeasure about President Trump's job performance while voicing angst about the cost of living and the nation's overall direction.

Preliminary results from a large national survey showed many voters went to the polls in a sour mood and looked to the midterm election for change in Washington as Democrats appeared well-positioned to take control of the House and had a shot at flipping the Senate.

High fuel and food prices were a top voter concern, with about 9 in 10 of the electorate saying the cost of living was a crucial or major factor in their thinking on how to vote for Congress, according to the first wave of results from a poll of more than 79,000 registered voters for the Associated Press and all the major television and cable news networks.

Voters blamed Trump for higher prices. Almost two-thirds said inflation was up more because of his policies, while the rest said it was more a result of factors outside his control.

Trump, a Republican, has cast the economy as on solid ground. In the closing weeks of the campaign, he said "the golden age of America is upon us," called the economy

Please turn to page A4

Divorce Lawyers To Clients: Break Up With AI

By Dalvin Brown

Steven Benmor, a Toronto family lawyer, recently drafted a prenuptial agreement the way he said his client asked. Then the client emailed him a 13-part list of revisions nearly as long as the prenup.

Some revisions went so deep into the weeds, Benmor said, that no human could have come up with them. Benmor knew his client had turned to an artificial-intelligence chatbot. And he knew that taking the time to explain why the chatbot was mistaken would require charging his client extra.

INSIDE



MARK J. TERRILL/AP

SPORTS
He's the biggest ball hog in the NBA—and nobody can stop him. **A18**

Trump Says U.S. Plans to End Military Aid to Israel This Year

WASHINGTON—President Trump said Tuesday that the U.S. would cut off military aid to Israel by the end of the year, suggesting the phaseout of grants to the U.S. ally could occur much faster than expected.

By Marianne LeVine, Anat Peled and Vera Bergengruen

"We won't be paying anymore to Israel," Trump said during an interview with Fox News on Election Day. "We've already agreed that by the end of this year, we won't be paying Israel."

Israeli officials, including from the security establishment, were surprised by Trump's comments, according to a person familiar with the matter.

The phasing out of direct U.S. military aid to Israel has been under discussion for months, with Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu of Israel publicly saying the country should eventually wean itself off U.S. assistance. Netanyahu had previously proposed eliminating direct military aid over the next decade.

The White House and an Israeli government spokesperson didn't respond to a request for comment.

"As far as paying Israel, Bibi Netanyahu and I have made a deal that we give Israel $4 billion a year and we

Please turn to page A10

40-Somethings Refuse to Accept They Can No Longer See

* * *

Vision loss proves particularly traumatic for a cohort in full denial of the aging process

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